

D673

Elementary Social Studies Curriculum

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A third-grade team is planning an inquiry unit on their town's history. The town has a historical museum and a famous bakery. Which is the best compelling question?

- A. "In what year was our town founded?"
- B. "What does the bakery sell?"
- C. "Name three buildings in our town."
- D. "Has our town changed more than it has stayed the same?"

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A fourth-grade class studying a 1906 earthquake looks at several sources. The class visited the library that week, and the unit ends in May. Which is a primary source?

- A. The library's catalog entry.
- B. A letter written by a survivor in 1906 describing the shaking.
- C. A children's book written in 2020 about the event.
- D. A 2015 encyclopedia article about the earthquake.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A historian in 1990 writes a book analyzing letters from soldiers in 1863. What kind of source is the book?

- A. Secondary
- B. Primary, because it quotes the letters.
- C. Neither, since books cannot be sources.
- D. Primary, because it is about 1863.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

Students read a newspaper account of a 1920s factory strike written by the factory owner. The article is printed on yellowed paper and has a large headline. What should students do before accepting its claims?

- A. Consider the owner's point of view and compare the account with workers' accounts and other records.
- B. Summarize it in their own words.
- C. Trust it because it is old.
- D. Accept it, since newspapers are always accurate.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A student writes, "Our school is two blocks north of the river, next to the fire station." She likes maps and has visited three states. Which theme of geography is she using?

- A. Movement
- B. Absolute location
- C. Relative location
- D. Region

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Farmers in a dry valley build canals to bring river water to their fields. Which theme of geography does this example best show?

- A. Movement
- B. Human-environment interaction
- C. Absolute location
- D. Place

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

Students want a stop sign added at a busy corner near their school. The corner has a coffee shop and a bus stop, and the school is 80 years old. Which part of government should they contact first?

- A. The U.S. Congress.
- B. The Supreme Court.
- C. The city or town council.
- D. The coffee shop owner.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A state passes a new law. Which branch of the state government is responsible for carrying it out?

- A. The executive branch, led by the governor.
- B. The federal government.
- C. The judicial branch.
- D. The legislative branch.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A class has \$50 from a bake sale. They can buy new books (\$50), art supplies (\$50), or a class plant (\$50). They choose books; art supplies were their second choice. The sale was held on a sunny Saturday. What is the opportunity cost?

- A. The books.
- B. The art supplies.
- C. The art supplies and the plant.
- D. The \$50.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student chose soccer practice over a movie, and said the opportunity cost was the movie. Which must have been true?

- A.** She had no other options.
- B.** The movie was her first choice.
- C.** The movie cost more money.
- D.** The movie was her next-best option.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A second-grade teacher plans a unit on a Native nation. Her classroom has a new sensory table, and families volunteered to bring snacks. Which plan best reflects multiple perspectives?

- A.** Teach only about the past, since cultures no longer change.
- B.** Focus the unit on the snacks families bring.
- C.** Use books and videos by members of the nation about their history and life today.
- D.** Make paper headdresses and try one traditional food.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

Fifth graders notice a lot of litter on the playground. The school's mascot is a hawk, and the class meets after lunch. Which project best reflects informed civic engagement?

- A.** Pick a solution before gathering any facts.
- B.** Memorize the three branches of government.
- C.** Draw posters of the mascot.
- D.** Collect data on where litter collects, propose solutions, and present them to the principal and student council.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A third-grade team is planning an inquiry unit on their town's history. ~~The town has a historical museum and a famous bakery.~~ Which is the best compelling question?

Target word: compelling question **Decides:** Open, debatable, engaging.

A	Adjacent category	A factual supporting question.
B	Camouflage	Reacts to a stem detail; not a historical inquiry.
C	Dropped element	Recall without argument.
D	Correct	Open and debatable; students must weigh evidence.

2. Answer B Concept 2

A fourth-grade class studying a 1906 earthquake looks at several sources. ~~The class visited the library that week, and the unit ends in May.~~ Which is a primary source?

Target word: identify a primary source **Decides:** Created at the time by a witness.

A	Camouflage	Unrelated to the event.
B	Correct	Created at the time by a participant.
C	Adjacent category	Secondary, even if it uses primary sources.
D	Confusion set	A later interpretation.

3. Answer A Concept 2 · transfer

A historian in 1990 writes a book analyzing letters from soldiers in 1863. What kind of source is the book?

Target word: reverse: classify a later work **Decides:** Created later, interpreting the originals.

A	Correct	Interprets events from a later time.
B	Inverted operation	Quoting primary sources does not make it primary.
C	Absolute language	Books can be either type.
D	Confusion set	Topic does not decide; creation time does.

4. Answer A Concept 3

Students read a newspaper account of a 1920s factory strike written by the factory owner. ~~The article is printed on yellowed paper and has a large headline.~~ What should students do before accepting its claims?

Target word: sourcing and corroboration **Decides:** Author has a point of view; compare other sources.

A	Correct	Sourcing plus corroboration.
B	Dropped element	Summarizing drops the evaluation.
C	Camouflage	Age does not mean accuracy.
D	Absolute language	Every source has a perspective.

5. Answer C Concept 4

A student writes, "Our school is two blocks north of the river, next to the fire station." ~~She likes maps and has visited three states.~~ Which theme of geography is she using?

Target word: classify the theme **Decides:** Location described in relation to other places.

A	Camouflage	Her travel is not the focus of the sentence.
B	Confusion set	Absolute location uses coordinates or an address.
C	Correct	Describes where it is relative to landmarks.
D	Adjacent category	Region groups areas by shared traits.

6. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

Farmers in a dry valley build canals to bring river water to their fields. Which theme of geography does this example best show?

Target word: reverse: example to theme **Decides:** People change the environment to meet needs.

A	Confusion set	Water moves, but the theme is people changing their environment.
B	Correct	People modify the land for farming.
C	Inverted operation	No coordinates are involved.
D	Adjacent category	Place describes features, not how people change them.

7. Answer C Concept 5

Students want a stop sign added at a busy corner near their school. ~~The corner has a coffee shop and a bus stop, and the school is 80 years old.~~ Which part of government should they contact first?

Target word: level of government **Decides:** Local streets are a local responsibility.

A	Adjacent category	Federal level; not responsible for local signs.
B	Confusion set	Judicial; interprets laws, does not install signs.
C	Correct	Local government handles local streets and signs.
D	Camouflage	Not a government body.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

A state passes a new law. Which branch of the state government is responsible for carrying it out?

Target word: reverse: from action to branch **Decides:** Carrying out laws is executive.

A	Correct	Executives enforce laws.
B	Adjacent category	Wrong level.
C	Confusion set	Interprets laws.
D	Inverted operation	Makes laws.

9. Answer B Concept 6

A class has \$50 from a bake sale. They can buy new books (\$50), art supplies (\$50), or a class plant (\$50). They choose books; art supplies were their second choice. ~~The sale was held on a sunny Saturday.~~ What is the opportunity cost?

Target word: opportunity cost **Decides:** Next-best alternative.

A	Inverted operation	That is what was chosen.
B	Correct	The second choice is what was given up.
C	Absolute language	Only the next-best alternative counts.
D	Confusion set	Money is the cost paid, not the alternative given up.

10. Answer D Concept 6 · transfer

A student chose soccer practice over a movie, and said the opportunity cost was the movie. Which must have been true?

Target word: reverse: infer ranking **Decides:** The movie was the next-best choice.

A	Dropped element	With no alternative, there is no opportunity cost.
B	Inverted operation	She chose soccer.
C	Confusion set	Opportunity cost is not just price.
D	Correct	Opportunity cost is the next-best alternative.

11. Answer C Concept 7

A second-grade teacher plans a unit on a Native nation. ~~Her classroom has a new sensory table, and families volunteered to bring snacks.~~ Which plan best reflects multiple perspectives?

Target word: multiple perspectives vs. tourist approach **Decides:** Everyday life, history, and people's own voices.

A	Absolute language	Cultures are living and current.
B	Camouflage	Food alone reduces the culture.
C	Correct	Authentic voices, present and past.
D	Adjacent category	A tourist approach.

12. Answer D Concept 8

Fifth graders notice a lot of litter on the playground. ~~The school's mascot is a hawk, and the class meets after lunch.~~ Which project best reflects informed civic engagement?

Target word: informed action **Decides:** Investigate, then take action with evidence.

A	Inverted operation	Action should follow inquiry.
B	Adjacent category	Knowledge without action.
C	Camouflage	Unrelated to the problem.
D	Correct	Evidence-based inquiry leads to action.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Inquiry arc: compelling and supporting questions	A compelling question is open, debatable, and engaging; supporting questions are narrower and help students gather the evidence to answer it, tied to standards.	Using a fact-recall question as the compelling question.	Planning a unit around a question.
2	Primary vs. secondary sources	A primary source was created by someone at the time of the event; a secondary source interprets it later.	Calling any old document primary, or any textbook-like source reliable.	When and by whom a source was created.
3	Sourcing and corroboration	Ask who created a source, when, and why; then compare it with other sources before trusting a claim.	Accepting one source as the full truth.	A single account of a disputed event.
4	Five themes of geography	Location (absolute or relative), place, human-environment interaction, movement, and region are distinct lenses.	Mixing absolute and relative location, or place and region.	A description of where something is or how people use land.
5	Levels and branches of government	Local, state, and federal governments handle different issues; legislative branches make laws, executive branches carry them out, and judicial branches interpret them.	Sending a local issue to Congress, or confusing who makes vs. enforces laws.	A civic problem and a question about who handles it.
6	Scarcity and opportunity cost	Because resources are limited, every choice has an opportunity cost: the value of the next-best alternative given up.	Counting all the alternatives, or the money spent, as the opportunity cost.	A choice among options with limited money or time.
7	Teaching culture through multiple perspectives	Teach cultures through everyday life, history, and people's own voices across the year, not only through food, festivals, and holidays.	A tourist approach that reduces cultures to costumes and snacks.	Planning a unit on a cultural group.
8	Civic engagement through informed action	Students take age-appropriate action on a real issue after investigating it with evidence.	Treating civic engagement as memorizing facts about government, or acting before inquiry.	A class project about a school or community problem.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Social Studies Curriculum is a thorough course tailored for educators looking to develop and implement a rich, engaging social studies curriculum for elementary-aged students. This course offers an in-depth examination of the key concepts and themes essential for teaching social studies effectively at the elementary level. Emphasizing a multidisciplinary approach, the curriculum covers history, geography, civics, economics, and culture, ensuring a well-rounded understanding of the subject. Additionally, it addresses the incorporation of standards into curriculum planning and the promotion of civic engagement among young learners. Through a blend of theoretical knowledge, this course aims to prepare educators with the tools necessary to align instructional strategies with social studies standards in meaningful ways.